



# FOREWORD

Samuel Johnson said in 1759: "No man will be a sailor who has contrivance enough to get himself into a jail; for being in a ship is being in a jail, with the chance of being drowned." In fact, the great man had understated his case. He was talking of sailors in general, not of those serving in navies in time of war. The naval prayer, first recorded in the 17th century and still part of the church services of Britain's Royal Navy, asks for preservation not only "from the dangers of the sea" but also "from the violence of the enemy." It is this "violence" that is the overriding theme of this book.

Naval warfare is almost as old as conflicts between armies on land, and as in land campaigns, it is the great battles that catch the imagination, the titanic clashes that can be said to have changed the course of history. Some, such as Cape Ecnomus between Rome and Carthage, or Leyte Gulf between the US and Japan in Word War II, involved vast fleets; others, such as the battles of Chesapeake Bay or the Nile, were fought by a relatively small number of ships. In spite of this, their strategic consequences were equally momentous.

While most nations have a long history of fighting on land, the list of countries that can be termed "maritime nations" is much shorter. There are certain nations and peoples that appear again and again as participants in the battles recorded in this book: in the Classical world the Carthaginians and the Greeks, in the Middle Ages the Venetians and the Genoese, in the age of European exploration the Spanish, the English, and the Dutch. Geography plays a key role, and some countries have little or no coastline, or difficult access to the high seas. For some, history teaches that the threat to national existence and way of life comes from across a land border, and this ever-present fact naturally colors thinking about defense. For maritime countries the sea looms larger in their national consciousness.

Historically, those nations with strong navies have developed in this way as a result of experience, sometimes harshly taught. They tend to depend on trade. The sea has always been the major highway for international commerce. Transporting goods in ships is much cheaper than moving them by land, and today, by air. International systems throughout the ages have depended on the free passage of people and





